Foundations of Experiential Therapy

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A Handbook for Experiential Therapists

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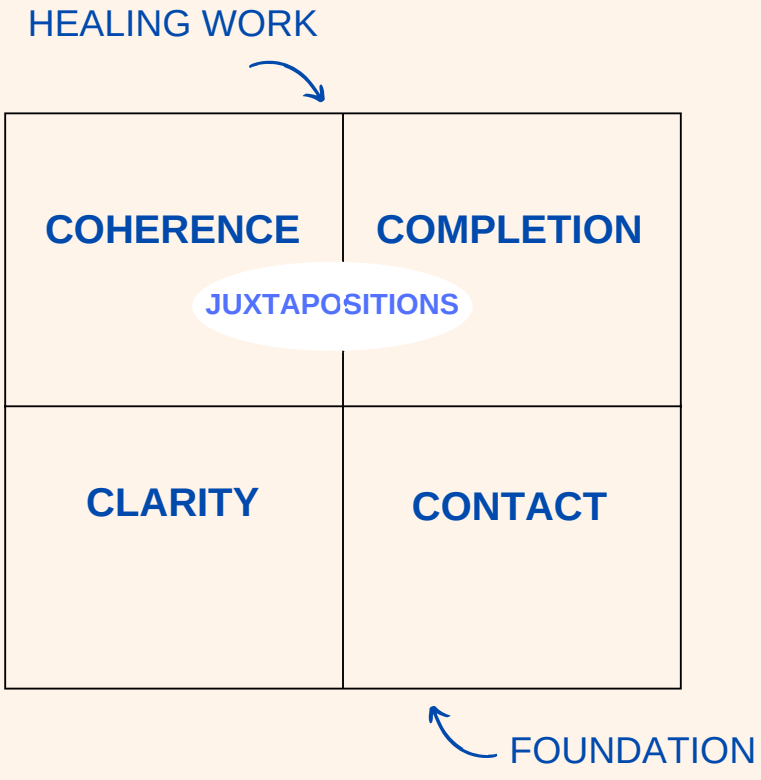
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Welcome!

In this manual, I will take you through the main stages of experiential work and introduce you to the types of question you might ask at each step. Please use this as a reference guide that orients you to all the pieces of clinical work worth learning about and as a jumping board for further research / training. This manual is not meant as a full (or vetted) training material related to the three therapies it draws from. But I hope it is helpful to those of us working to integrate between them.

I will be connecting the question not only to 'steps of the work,' but also to the four main pieces/types of work, as outlined in a diagram below that I crafted for my students.

The bottom 2 quadrants are pieces of clinical work that set the stage for the deeper healing work. And the top 2 quadrants are the two paths of deeper work itself. It is these two deeper pieces of work that often lead to juxtapositions, especially if they are paired (more on next page).



The 4 C's of Experiential Work

CONTACT is all about finding the right observing distance (ie a mindful, regulated, resourced, curious stance). We don't need perfect "Self energy" (an IFS term), but we do need enough.

CLARITY is all about keeping things organized in terms of the various elements that emerge (being able to make discernments between different parts or issues or feelings, so that one piece of work can be focused on with clarity and precision). This is related to concept of 'Therapeutic Focus.'

Once the stage is set by the foundation of both CONTACT and CLARITY (ie you've helped the client enter a mindful, compassionate witnessing of a very specific part of their experience), then the top 2 C's become possible. Those are:

COHERENCE is all about understanding the coherence of the feeling / impulse / pattern. In other words *why it makes sense* based on one's unconscious world of meanings (ie schemas).

COMPLETION is about completing unfinished emotional 'work' that got blocked. This could be working through unprocessed grief, or anger, or self-protection. Completion work is not *always* necessary, but is a very common and powerful way of creating disconfirmations, since so many of our schemas are around not being able to complete a healthy response. Often our old wounds are around blocked healthy emotional responses (like crying, using anger to set boundaries, etc.), and the subsequent schemas we pick up that our healthy responses are dangerous, or at least pointless. And one way to disconfirm this is through a new experience of completing, rather than defending against, them (our emotions, impulses, activations).

OTHER TERMS USED IN MANUAL

COHERENCE THERAPY TERMS:

SCHEMA (also called 'emotional learning') is a prediction held in implicit memory (subcortically) around what things mean for our safety or wellbeing, as well as how we should respond to protect ourselves.
JUXTAPOSITIONS occur when our brain simultaneously witnesses two predictions / knowings / 'truths' that can't BOTH be true (one '**disconfirms**' the other).
MEMORY RECONSOLIDATION is the brain's innate mechanism for erasing or updating old schemas / emotional learnings. It is triggered by the experience of a juxtaposition (or what brain researchers called a '**mismatch**' experience).

AEDP TERMS:

METAPROCESSING is 'processing the process,' in other words spending time processing one's experience of a positive shift, and the work that led to it, and the new meanings it opens to view.

IFS TERMS:

Self Energy holds all the qualities of our true, adult self. It is the Self that emerges when we are not overcome by one of our parts, but rather in a brain state where our full emotional intelligence is online (what Daniel Siegel would call **neural integration**)
Unblending is the act of stepping back from our parts and observing them in a mindful way. When the 'seat of our consciousness' is being governed by a part (for instance when we are 'triggered'), we are **blended** with that part. When we unblend, we have access to Self Energy.

EXPERIENTIAL QUESTIONS AS THE WORK BEGINS

STEP 1: FINDING A POINT OF FOCUS (CLARITY work)

STEP 2: INVITING INTERNAL AWARENESS (CONTACT work)

STEP 1 AND 2 are not linear, but both are important at the beginning, and must be established before deeper exploration can occur. So I'm putting these questions at the front, but of course they flow through all of the work!

STEP 1:
FIND POINT OF FOCUS ("CLARITY" WORK)

IDENTIFYING FOCUS / TARGET ISSUE

One of the first places CLARITY comes into play is around finding the point of focus for the work. This would certainly be done during an intake, but also at the beginning of sessions to orient toward the piece of work that will be approached that day.

"*What is it you would like me to help you with?*"
Use any question you already use in order to learn from people why they came to therapy. The thing to remember here is to be active in helping the client find an internal focus. If they launch into complaints about other people, for instance, gently return them to the task of finding an internal, psychological problem they want help with.

"As we are beginning, I really want to spend some time with you figuring out how we can best use our time, and what exactly it is you'd like my help with. Let's take a number of minutes here, because I want to be clear as to exactly what you are wanting to work on. What kind of change you are looking for, or what suffering you are experiencing that we need to understand and resolve. Is that an okay place to start?"

"If our work ended up being incredibly helpful to you, what kind of change would you experience?"

Or, at the beginning of a session (during ongoing work), you might ask:

"What is it you are wanting to focus on today?"

"Last week we were doing work around your difficulty telling people when you disagree. Is there anything that would keep us from continuing with that work today?"

"Take a moment as we get started just to let yourself 'arrive.' Then just check inside and see what it is that you'd most like to work on today."

WHEN FINDING FOCUS ISN'T EASY

People may need your help fully articulating a 'psychological problem,' (for lack of a better word). While it is true that people suffer due to hard life circumstances, most people have some place(s) inside that could use healing work. And that is what we want to aim to clarify. So if they begin to talk about a conflict with their partner, for instance, you'd certainly want to start by offering empathic reflection around their suffering, but then soon after ask questions like:

"*So as we begin doing some work around this, I'd really like to explore with you what it is you'd like to work on regarding this piece. I mean, it does sound very stressful. But I'm also curious if there's any place inside where you respond in a way that creates more difficulty for you, or you'd like to change. Whether you self-attack, or feel overwhelmed, or shut-down, or get defensive. You know? I'm curious how you find yourself responding to this difficulty, and if there's any place you're getting stuck that perhaps we could work on?"*

"Is there any part of your response to this all that you'd like to change, or be different?"

"How do you find yourself responding when this happens? Do you feel you are managing it well, or is there some place it takes you--either in your emotions or behaviors--that you would like to see shift?"

"Wow, that aggressive tone from your boss sure sounds difficult to take. If our work were to be successful, how would you want to feel or respond differently than you are now?"

"When I think about suffering, I always visualize it as half coming from things happening on the outside, and half coming from how we respond to it...either in terms of behaviors, or emotional responses. Is there a response you have to this situation that might be part of what makes those moments so difficult?"

FLESHING OUT POINT OF FOCUS

When finding a focus for therapy, we need to understand what clients mean by the words they use, because we use words fairly idiosyncratically. So what one person means when they say 'depressed,' or 'low self-esteem,' could be far different from what another person means. So you need to ask questions like:

"Can you describe in detail what you mean by 'depressed'? What does this look and feel like for you?"

Because we want to get as clear a picture as possible as to what the client is wanting to change, we need to go past labels and general descriptions, and hear from the client exactly how the issue plays out for them. Like getting an 'operational definition' with **when/where/what**.

For the '**what**' you might simply ask for a description, or say:
"If I were to summarize back what I've heard, what would I need to say that would let you know I understand the most important elements and have a clear sense for what you are experiencing?"

Get totally clear on the details: "What kind of mistake does this seem to relate to? Are *all* mistakes horrible, or just moral ones?"

For the '**when/where**' (in terms of identifying triggers):
"I know you mentioned that this sinking feel (anxiety/obsessing) happens all the time, but are there times it is even worse?" (Even when people experience chronic concerns like low mood, they usually aren't totally consistent. They might be slightly worse during certain situations or times of the year, or around certain people, or after certain triggers, etc.) *"Are there certain people who this plays out with more commonly or powerfully?" (or a certain situation / moment, etc.)*

For the '**when/where**' you can also try to begin identifying possible historical pieces: *"Was there a particular time in your life this issue began?" Then, "can you tell me about that time?" or "Does this experience feel familiar to you?"*

CONTRACTING

Sometimes step 1 is super easy and just flows effortlessly into step 2, where people naturally begin to turn inward and explore. However, sometimes people need a little more time to be “Socialized to Therapy” (that’s a research term). It can help to provide some explanation around what the process is all about.

There is a particular version of this step when the person doesn’t actually have awareness that their pattern is causing them difficulty. They may be aware of the unwanted ‘side-effects’ of their pattern, but don’t link it to the pattern itself. For instance, they might come in complaining about conflict with their partner, but not be aware that something they are doing is contributing to the problem. Whew! So that’s a whole other step that is occasionally needed! I think the bottom line in this case (where the ‘symptom’ is actually ‘ego-syntonic,’) is to gently begin making the connection between the pattern and their suffering. And then to respectfully explore the cost of that pattern. Once they see the cost, they will be more motivated to take that pattern as a point of focus for therapy.

For most people, however, the need to slow down is simply to make the process feel safe, and a lot of that has to do with clarity...with the person understanding a bit about what will be asked of them and why. That clarity helps them fully ‘sign-up’ and feel empowered to collaborate.

In essence, we are wanting to regulate any shame or anxiety that might be triggered by the idea of exploring inwardly. Clarity as to the process can help. It can also help to normalize (explain why we ALL struggle).

In the next page, I’ll offer a few different versions of ‘introductions to the process’. But I encourage you to write out at least 5 of your own. You might want to craft one you can use with all new clients, and then a few others you might draw from as needed. Try a few different styles as well (how you describe process to an artist might be different than an engineer). We need to be ready if a client asks “Why are we doing this?” or “How will this help?”

CONTRACTING (2)

Clients need to have some sense around why you are asking the kind of questions you are asking. So come up with your own way to describe the process. Some ideas are below.

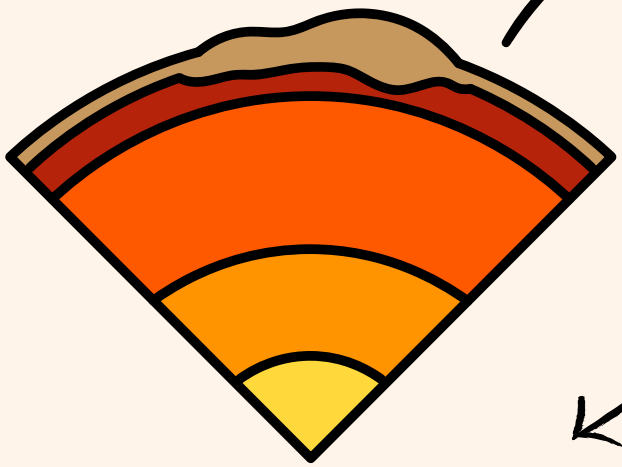
"Would you like for us to explore what might be underneath this?"
Honestly this simply question is often all that is needed. The phrase 'underneath this' hints at the fact that there may be something underneath to explore. And most people get that...

"Okay, so yes, that sounds like something really worth exploring...why you never say no to anyone. So, if you are willing, let's really focus our exploration right here, and just see what we can uncover about this."

If they seem to need more, you could say things like:
"You know, often when we find ourself stuck in a pattern, there is some unconscious belief that is driving it. You see, our brain evolved to just pick up these imprints around how we should respond to things. And they are wired in a way that we aren't naturally aware of them. So when we want to change a reaction we have, the first step is to slow down and see what kind of imprint--or unconscious belief-- is driving that response in the first place. Of course as we move along, we might bump into underlying emotions as well, and I'll be here to help you work through those. How does that all sound?"
Depending on how they respond you might continue with:
"So in our work, I'll be continually asking you to slow down and notice or explore an internal reaction. Sometimes I might ask you to check inside for an emotional reaction, or to see what you feel. Sometimes I'll be guiding you to sense into what something means to you--not rationally, but on a gut level. Honestly, this might feel strange at first. Cause most of us have never been invited to deeply reflect and be mindful of ourself like this. But if you are open to giving it a try, I'm am here to guide you." Again, write down 5-10 versions that capture what you believe therapy is really about. And then study the ones you really like.

I like to think of the work as proceeding in layers. Here is the first layer we have reviewed so far:

Step 1: Finding a Point of Focus



Presenting Problem

Clarification

What do you mean exactly?
What do you mean by depression?
What does it look and feel like?

Where/When/With Whom
Context!

TRIGGERS?

STEP 2:
INVITE INNER FOCUS ("CONTACT" WORK)

CONTACT WORK

Once you feel that you and the client have gotten on the same page around what they are wanting to work on (including what the issue looks and feels like and when / where it plays out), then you can shift into creating compassionate contact with whatever might be underneath. This means we are mindfully turning toward whatever comes up so it can teach us about what the unconscious mind is holding in relation to this issue.

If we can imagine that clarifying the target issue is like finding the place in the ground to dig, CONTACT is more about actually digging, ie slowing down and inviting into awareness whatever hidden part of us or our experience is ready to be seen or witness / explored.

Now, sometimes when we begin the digging, it's like we hit a little cavern, and the person just falls right into it! In other words, they become overwhelmed because too much is coming at once. Helping them come out of the cavern and regain a bit more distance is then important, and is still a type of CONTACT work, because you can't have meaningful contact with a part of your experience if it is flooding you. That is why Contact is not only about moving closer to the material, and more about finding the RIGHT DISTANCE (basically same as IFS idea of remaining unblended). Knowing how to deal with overwhelm is important, but I will outline that later in this handout. So for now let's simply explore how to DEEPEN contact through asking questions that invite the client to turn toward their experience and open their awareness inwardly.

To summarize, once the client has identified a particular point of focus, the next step is to create a mindful internally-focused awareness such that the part of them or their experience that they are wanting to explore can be explored. I think of this as creating a 'LISTENING SPACE.' And it is truly a sacred space, where there is room to simply witness what is real without needing to judge or turn away.

WORKING WITH AN EXAMPLE

One of the best ways to begin making contact with the piece you are wanting to explore is to **ask for an example**. You might say:

"I'd like you to think of an example where this played out. You could either pick a recent example, or perhaps one that really captures your usual experience of (berating yourself for a mistake). Does one come to mind?"

"Could you think of a time that this played out recently? Or maybe a typical example?"

"Good. If you will, I'd love you just to walk me through that moment. You might even tell it to me in the first person, like "I'm just walking in the door. And I see that my wife isn't home yet." I'll keep slowing you down so that we can really explore what is happening internally and not miss anything."

"I'd like you just to move through that moment in your mind, and notice the first moment that the (sinking feeling) comes up."

Then, "What is happening just before that moment?"

"If you can just rewind and kind of freeze frame that moment. What thoughts or feelings are going through your mind?"

"Okay, so yes, there seems to be a lot that happens inside right there. Right then when she turns away...yes...let's hover right there.' (or 'linger there', 'or 'stay there' or 'get curious and try to see what we can discover here').

"So as your brother is walking toward you, what are you noticing? Either in him or you. What things are coming up as he approaches?"

WORKING WITH AN EXAMPLE (2)

Working within an example is incredibly helpful. It allows you to slow down, rewind, get curious about what is/was happening internally (so you can then move either in the direction of exploring COHERENCE or doing COMPLETION work). Examples help the client come into genuine contact with their mind or experience as it actually happens/happened, rather than just talking vaguely or intellectually about it. Examples provide a portal back into their experience so they can explore it.

Of course, sometimes the issue is active in the moment, or is playing out in the room (like the client noticing difficulty being honest with the therapist and an impulse to please them, or the client suddenly getting tense when asked what they are feeling). It is therefore also an option to simply notice experience in real-time, almost using the actual moment in the office as the 'example.' Then you might say something like:

"Okay, thanks for sharing that. Great. So can we rewind to the moment you noticed wanting to please me? If we can go back...maybe we can just slow that down and see what was happening internally for you."

"So when I asked how you felt, what happened inside? I thought I saw you getting a bit tense about it?...Oh, you did? Okay, yeah, so let's just slow down with that moment and see what happens inside right there."

Examples aren't the only option to start deepening the work--in fact, in IFS they use the 6 F's (you can easily find these online). This is a more somatic approach, where you simply begin to try to touch into and make contact with a part. This is also great, but I do find using an example to be powerful and reliable. So I would suggest trying it out.

In the next pages, I will list out a number of different kinds of 'CONTACT QUESTIONS,' starting with slowing people down. Practicing them will give you a good feeling for how to invite inner awareness of experience (rather than asking questions that take the client into their heads).

GUIDING CLIENT TO SLOW DOWN

“Let’s slow down right here. Yeah (therapist takes long breath).”

“Let’s stay with this piece, and begin to explore what is here. Is that okay?”

“Let’s linger here.” OR “Let’s stay here together.” OR “Let’s hover here.”

“Can we pause here and just notice?”

“Hmmm…okay, let’s aim toward discovering what is underneath this. Does that sound good to you?”

“So let’s pause here and see where we are. Hmm…yes…you were saying XYZ, but we weren’t clear about (why that feeling emerged, etc.). Okay, yes. So let’s just see if your mind is willing to show us something about that.”

“Is it feeling workable to continue with this exploration? Just slowing noticing each piece as it comes?”

“Is it okay to slow down like this, where we are really just inviting each piece to come up and gradually add to what we are able to be in touch with here?”

“I really appreciate how you are willing to explore and stay curious with me like this, where we just keep aiming our awareness toward the next piece your mind is willing to reveal here about why XYZ feels so necessary…”

“Feels like what you just said was really important. Let’s just stay with that for a second. Let’s let that, kind of, ‘breath’.”

“Wow, could you say that again?” (Or the therapist might repeat the words). (alt: “I’d love you to say XYZ again, and then take a full breath.”)

GUIDING CLIENT TO NOTICE INNER SIGNALS“

What was/is that like for you?”

“How was that for you to...”

“What are you noticing now?”

“What is it like to say that out loud?” OR “What is that like to hear me say that?” (I ask this every time I offer any of my own thoughts).

“What is that like to acknowledge?”

“What are you noticing as you tell me this?”

“Are there feelings there about this?”

“What’s coming up (coming to mind) right now?”

“What are the tears saying?”

“What is the tension trying to do?”

“What do you become aware of as we linger here?”

“What are you noticing in your body as you say this?”

“Can you place your mind inside that place in your belly (or tense spot, etc.), and ask it if it is willing to show you?”

“What are you tracking now?”

“Would you be willing to put a hand on that spot? Just to take a moment to connect right there. Yeah, just like giving a hand of support (pause). And then just see what you notice in that spot. What are you holding there?”

GUIDING CLIENT TOWARD COMPASSIONATE CURIOSITY ("SELF ENERGY")

"Is is possible just to be curious about this together? Just to kind of offer your mind some space to show us what this is all about?"

"How are you feeling toward this part of you (or this sadness, etc.)?" (This is a classic IFS question to check to see if there is enough 'SELF ENERGY' (or what I'm calling 'CONTACT')).

"How are you relating to this, as you are describing it? Does it feel workable, or like it's too much? (alt: are you feeling pretty open and understanding toward yourself here, or is there judgement coming up?).

If the client says that they are judging or scared of or angry toward a part of their experience, then you would shift focus and work with this judging/scared part first (whether you call it a part, or just a concern, etc). First you can simply as it to 'soften back,' but if it can't, then you would want to listen to that part's (or client's) 'concerns' and address them all. This might look like making a plan for how it will be safe to move forward without getting overwhelmed, etc., or explaining the concept of coherence so they realize that any part of their mind is simply trying to help them, and has learned to do exactly what it is doing for a good reason, even if we don't know that reason yet. Explaining the concept of coherence (or 'no bad parts') can really help increase compassion.

IFS is particularly focused on making sure the client is in 'Self Energy' (rather than being blended with a part that is judgmental/scared/angry toward the target part). HOWEVER, while it might be true that you need enough 'Self Energy' online for the work to proceed, I have found that you don't really need full self-energy. So I'm usually much less attentive to checking for full self-compassion (unless this is something that we are purposefully working on). I think you can move forward as long as the therapist is in Self energy the client is reasonably grounded / regulated (and curious). (More on working with dysregulation later).

WORKING WITH DEFENSES

While the therapist is always encouraging the client to get stay in contact with their deeper mind, this is particularly true (and sometimes tricky) when people are in active *avoidance* of their mind. As a general rule, I wouldn't right away 'call this out,' but rather simply try to use my presence and guidance to steer them inward (in AEDP, they call this 'melting the defense'). **We have to do our part to make it safe, as well as clear what we are asking, etc.**!! So being patient (persistent) and doing our part to create safety is always the first step. But if this isn't enough, then it may be that the avoidance itself needs to become the first 'point of focus' for therapy.

If we are going to work with defenses, we need to first 'make the implicit, explicit' (ie make the pattern conscious and see if they are something the client actually wants to work on). It is super important not to come across as shaming, and usually that comes down to tone of voice.
"I notice that when I ask you to check inside (or report on your experience, etc.), something seems to block that (or something seems difficult about that, or you tend to shift right back into the story, sort of skipping over what is happening inside). Do you know what I mean?" If they do know what you mean, then you can shift into contracting around whether they would like to explore what is underneath that. Sometimes psycho-ed helps (around why you are asking them to look inside at all).

Remember, not only might people be afraid of opening up, they also might not know how BECAUSE NO ONE HAS EVER BEEN INTERESTED IN THEIR INNER WORLD! Sometimes reflecting this can actually be a very loving way to help people want to learn to track inward.

"I notice that when I ask questions about your inner experience, you sometimes seem at a loss, or even say 'I don't know.' As if it's a bit foreign to describe your experience to someone, or even be asked about it. That makes me wonder if perhaps you've never had someone be this deeply curious about your inner world?"
A reflection like that is often very powerful, and can bring up emotion. So I would definitely follow up with, *"What's it like to hear me say that?"*

WORKING WITH DEFENSES: CLASSIC IFS TECHNIQUES

Different therapies have different ways of working with defenses, but all of these revolve around 'making the implicit, explicit.' (ie bringing the defense to awareness so it can be explored). And they all emphasize non-judgement. In fact, it can be useful to not only *accept* the defense, but also *honor* it. And appreciate the ways it has protected the client in the past (ie do some 'coherence work' around the defense).

IFS does this piece very overtly (although it can be done in more subtle ways that don't necessarily include parts language). In fact a non-parts language version might be something like:

"Okay, so let's just learn about this then. We notice that when we step closer to looking at XYZ, that you dissociated (or 'that you tend to change subjects or feel tense, etc.). So let's not try to change that in any way. Let's just see if we can understand. Is that okay?"

While you don't need to use parts language, the IFS method does give a nice template. And that is this: when bumping up against defenses, we name them as a 'part' and get curious how that part believes it is protecting us.

"I notice that you have a strong intellectual part that likes to answer for you. Almost trying to figure it out, rather than checking inwardly. Do you know what I mean?"

"It seems like while a part of you really wants to explore why you might be procrastinating, another part is really uncomfortable with this topic and you start getting pretty tense."

"It seems like, while a part of you is willing to tell me about XYZ, another part is really judging this behavior (or is minimizing your pain, etc.). Am I right on that? I am? Okay, would you be open to talking to that part?"

WORKING WITH DEFENSES: CLASSIC IFS TECHNIQUES (2)

When we describe their defense as a 'part,' it invites the client to gain some observing distant. Of course, once we have observed an 'intellectualizing part' or a 'story-telling' part, the next step is to say: "Is the story-telling part willing to soften back?" If it isn't willing, you can temporarily turn your focus toward it (such that it is now 'the target'). At that point you might ask the protector part IFS questions like:

"Could you ask the intellectualizing part what it is afraid would happen if it softened back and allowed us to explore the insecure part (or your anger, etc.) more directly?" Or if you'd rather not use parts language: "So it seems like telling me more about the anger is feeling unworkable in some way. So let's not push past that at all. I'd rather simply ask you to check inside for what feels hard or unwelcome about it."

When you have a clear sense what the protector part (defense) is afraid of, then you can work to address those fears (like, if the fear is of becoming overwhelmed, you can make an agreement with the exile ahead of time to not flood the system--we will talk about this technique at some point). If you can actually assuage all the fears of the protector part, then it is likely to step aside so a new experience (of deepening awareness of the suffering that is being protected from) can emerge. If this approach sounds appealing, I suggest diving into some IFS training.

As an aside, this moment is a choice point as to whether to lean into COMPLETION or COHERENCE work. Asking protector parts to 'soften back' is an example of COMPLETION work because once the protector 'softens back,' it allows a new experience (where emotions can finally flow, or the exile can finally be heard from) to be completed. However, when you ask protector parts what they are afraid of, this is an example of COHERENCE WORK. Because you are slowing down to understand what emotional learning is necessitating the 'defense'.

WORKING WITH DEFENSES: PATIENCE and NON-AGENDA

One of the most powerful ways to create safety is through holding a stance that we might call 'non-agenda,' where we purposefully let go of any need to rush the work or have the client go deeper or do anything differently, etc. Yes, ultimately we do want change (and relief and wellness) for our client. But we aren't urgent about making it happen on our time-line (ie right now!). Plus, rushing and pushing doesn't work (or if it works temporarily, it will backfire). So instead we simply trust the process and focus on the work, rather than the outcome.

I've been surprised how often simply giving 'permission' (or encouraging the client to give themselves permission) to show up exactly as they are showing up immediately shifts something. I used to have a client who didn't like coming to therapy and would express feeling grumpy to be there, and I'd always say, "Okay, just let yourself really make space for that grumpiness. Let's invite it to be with us, if we can. It's allowed here." Of course then we'd look at what need the grumpiness was expressing, etc., but the first step was just permission. One thing I love about IFS is they always give permission for parts to show up as they are showing up. So if a part is turned away and not trusting...then the guidance might be, "Is it okay for you to have this part be turned away? Yes? Good, then just let them know it's okay for them to show up however they want. There is no requirement that they trust you." Ironically, expressing understanding around why a part (or person) might NOT trust, and not pushing that they get over that, is one of the fastest ways to *build* trust.

The main point here is that our systems don't like being 'managed,' or being related to with 'agenda.' We want to offer listening and attunement, not 'fixing.' And when that intention is clear, it often creates a lot of opening. This means we have to work with our own 'parts' that *do* have agenda (that either need the client to get better faster, or to like us, etc.). We all have those parts, and we work with them the best we can. Similarly, we often need to work with client's parts that hold agenda (for instance that want the inner child to feel better right away, etc.).

WORKING WITH DEFENSES: PATIENCE and NON-AGENDA (2)

Holding a stance of non-agenda is a kind of spiritual practice, I feel. One that we want to feel into with our bodies and hearts. It is part of creating a 'sacred space,' or what I like to call a 'listening space.'

I know holding this space isn't always easy, so we have to be merciful with ourselves. We often are under pressure from employers, or even our own parts. That being said, we can slowly begin to learn to embody this kind of slow, spacious, compassionate witnessing. In IFS, they call our capacity to simply hold space (with curiosity and compassion) our Self Energy. If we are in 'agenda,' then we aren't in Self Energy, but rather blended with a part. There is no shame in that at all, but it is useful to explore our inner world / parts, and engage in deep healing work.

As a final thought, I'll just mention that patience is a true gift. Imagine a child who is angry at their parent, and won't open the door. Even if the child screams, 'go away!', deep down they want the parent just to sit by the door. Not to barge in, but not to go away either. Just to wait until there's an opening. To bring this point to life, I'll share the lyrics to a song I wrote my last week in graduate school, when we were asked to bring in a song that captures what kind of therapist we want to be.

PATIENT WITH ME

Start counting down from 10
And if I'm not found by then
Could you go round again?
I'm hidden somewhere deep

Even from myself sometimes
But you know how hard I try
You have the most patient eyes
You know how to wait and see

And when I'm not ready yet
I'm grateful for how you let
Me take my time to get
To where I can let you in

And it's a holding still
A holding me close until
I know it's safe to feel
All that I'm hold here

I want to share the part of me
That's a vast and ancient sea
And it helps me get there
When you're are patient with me

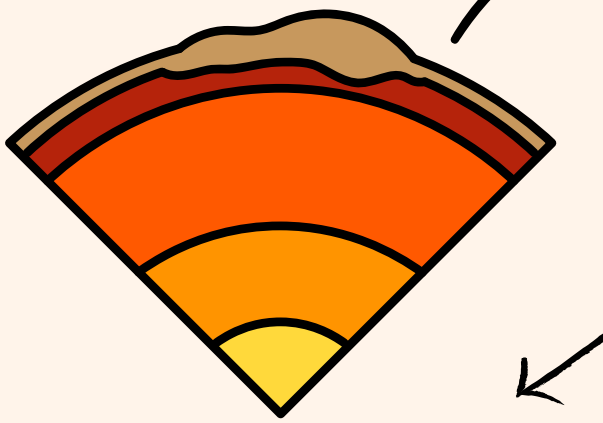
So here I am found again
And you're like a second skin
That I am resting in
You're also resting here...

In this cocoon we make
When we know how to wait
Sometimes it's time we take
When we take the chance to love

Cause all of us need to know
That we will be taken slow
That there is no too late
That we are worth the wait

I want to share the part of me
That's a vast and ancient sea
And it helps me get there
When you are patient with me

Continuing with the Layers:



Presenting Problem

Clarification

What do you mean exactly?
What do you mean by depression?
What does it look and feel like?

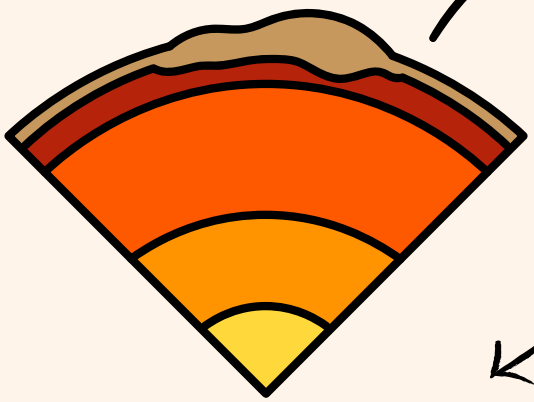
Where/When/With Whom
Context!

Example!!!

SLOW DOWN /
“REVIVIFY” THE SCENE

CONTACT AND INNER EXPLORATION

Continuing with the Layers:



Presenting Problem

Clarification

What do you mean exactly?
What do you mean by depression?
What does it look and feel like?

Where/When/With Whom
Context!

Example!!!

SLOW DOWN /
“REVIVIFY” THE SCENE

CONTACT AND INNER EXPLORATION

*Oops! We moved too fast!

Dysregulation / Flashback!

Let’s talk about this possibility next!

PREVENTING EMOTIONAL OVERWHELM

As I mentioned, there are two elements involved in CONTACT (which you can relate to Daniel Siegel's idea of 'separation plus linkage' (language which he borrowed from complexity theory). First, we need to help people slow down, sidestep defenses, and open up more inner awareness (ie we need enough 'linkage'--or connection with what is underneath). But we also need to keep things within the 'window of tolerance,' which means we also need enough 'separation' (observing distance). This balance is sometimes a dance, because we are inviting more emotional information to flow upward into conscious awareness, but also titrating the process enough to allow the experience to feel safe and workable.

On the next page, I will show a diagram I often use with my students, called the "Needs and Resources Channels." The point of this diagram is to show that everyone has two things inside of them. First, they have places inside that hold unmetabolized (or even recognized) pain, unmet needs, unprocessed trauma memories, unsolved problems, etc. Basically, places that deserve attention and resources, so that work can be done to create a shift or change! Second, they have resources inside them (and often on the outside, for instance from others), that are not being recognized or tapped into. The goal is to slowly become more and more aware of **both**. Why? Well, when we can bring our deepest resources to our deepest pains or needs, that is when true healing can happen.

This work on the 'two channels' is more applicable once we begin completion work, because contacting both channels is what allows us to find the places inside that actually need to 'complete' some processing, while holding enough resource to do so. You see, completions happen (whether more superficial completions, or deepening ones), when 'resource meets need.' In other words, once our system is able to look at our true pain / emotions / needs in a resourced manner, it is simply natural for things to begin to move toward healing / processing / problem solving / insights (ie 'completion'). And once we've seen this happen on one level, it gives us courage to go more deeply.

Resource and Needs "Channels"

Resource		Needs
Superficial Sense of One's Resources	The goal is to slowly move deeper in each channel, while staying in the same general level on each (so they are matched). If you have deep sense of resource, but no awareness of the place that NEEDS that resource, you are likely in defenses (and what is the point of feeling 'adult' if you aren't using that adult to heal the deepest wounds inside!). Conversely, if you are too 'deeply' aware of pain, without awareness of your true inner resource ("Self"), (or other resources, like the therapist, or God, etc.,) then you are likely to become flooded.	Superficial Sense of One's Needs / Pain
		
Deepening Sense of One's Resources		Deepening Sense of One's Needs / Pain
		
Contact with Deepest Resources		Contact with Deepest Needs / Pain

Resource and Needs "Channels"

Resource

Superficial Sense of One's Resources

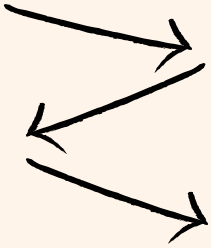


Deepening Sense of One's Resources



Contact with Deepest Resources

Somatic experiencing practitioners use a word called 'pendulation,' which represents a natural 'rhythm' in the nervous system, where awareness swings between the hard things (danger, activation), and the resources. The idea is to support this pendulation.



When we can support pendulation (where we find a natural rhythm between focusing on the emerging emotions and resources), then people naturally deepen their awareness of both. At each level, more 'security' is established. In fact, to me, this is the definition of 'earned security', but also the definition of emotional depth, as well as resilience. This is CONTACT work in motion, where we create contact between the pain and some resource / relationship, see what shift this brings, and then take a step deeper, still maintaining both. And step by step, we move the experience 'all the way through,' to completion.

Needs

Superficial Sense of One's Needs / Pain



Deepening Sense of One's Needs / Pain



Contact with Deepest Needs / Pain

Resource and Needs "Channels"

Resource	Possible Techniques:	Needs
Co-regulation "Is it okay to be with this?" "Can you feel me with you?"		Emotion-Focused Experiential ?'s "What do you notice now?"
UNBLENDING from protectors / Accessing SELF	Mindfulness	Asking Client to Ask the Part
Tracking Coherence / Asking Protectors What They Fear	Somatic Tracking	Asking Protector Parts/Defenses to Soften Back
ATTENDING TO NEEDS / Asking Protectors What They Need to Feel SAfe	Mindfulness and Somatic Tracking play double duty, working to foster awareness of 'Needs' (emotions, parts) AND Resources, often at the same time.	Experiential Techniques (sentence compl, imagery, etc.) Always wondering: 'what's under this?'
UNBLENDING FROM EXILES If Overwhelmed	Let's talk about this situation next!	"What was the worst / strongest you've experienced of (being left)?"

Regulating Overwhelmed States

The ‘two channels’ diagram tracks a way of working that is aimed at avoiding emotional overwhelm. However, overwhelm (what IFS people would call ‘blending with an exile’) does happen--even when we do everything right! In fact, sometimes people come in already overwhelmed! So it is important to learn to work with dysregulated states, and actively help clients regain their bearings.

There are so many options when working with emotion regulation, including using what people typically think of as ‘resources’ (like deep breathing, self-care, nature, relaxation, self-soothing, somatic techniques, etc.). Depending on what kind of work you like to do, you may enjoy building up some of these offerings (like if you do somatic work, you will no doubt learn some somatic ways of regulating one’s nervous system, etc.). You can also dive into Deb Dana’s work (drawing on polyvagal theory), if you work with people with severe trauma and really need a little ‘extra’ around this piece. And of course, all therapists should continually work on their ability to be warm and create safety interpersonally through their capacity for attunement!

However, my two main ‘go-to’s when it comes to emotion regulation are less about simply ‘soothing’ someone, and more around coming into awareness that what they are experiencing is a memory, rather than just pure emotion. In other words, much of the time when people are dysregulated, it is because they are having an ‘emotional flashback,’ where old pain is being remembered…but, because the pain / experience itself was never processed (or never integrated by the hippocampus, as is common with trauma)…it feels like it is happening NOW. In other words, it comes up more like implicit memory than explicit memory. And because implicit memory feel like ‘this is just the nature of reality,’ versus ‘this is a memory of the past I am remembering,’ the memory can emerge more like a ‘flashback’. Unlike a traditional full-on flashback (where the person hallucinates the actual scene), this is more like a somatic version, where they relive the experience in their bodies / emotions / what it ‘felt like’ to be there.

Regulating Overwhelmed States (2)

When people (somatically / emotionally) relive their old pain in this way, they don't know they are having a memory. So it feels current, which both makes it more intense and alarming, but also more confusing (like, "Why am I reacting in this way?!!"). So the aim here is to help them realize that what they are experiencing is memory-based, and thereby both get some distance from it, while realizing they aren't crazy, nothing horrible is necessarily happening NOW, etc.

I therefore simply start by explaining the science of emotional flashbacks (very briefly). I might say: "You know, Devon, would you mind if I shared something that might help? Well, my sense is that some of what you are feeling right now might actually be what I call an 'emotional flashback'. In other words, the current situation is reminding you of how bad it felt back then (when your mom would attack you), and an actual memory got triggered. But the thing is, really painful memories are stored in the brain differently. Because of stress, the brain often fails to put a 'time-stamp' on the memory, which means that when we remember it, it doesn't feel like remembering, it feels like reliving. And all the old feelings just flood through our body, as if the old situation is happening right now. You see what I mean? Yeah. You might have heard of how flashbacks can bring back a whole scene so it's like the person is back there...this is like that, but more in the body or emotions." After checking whether this makes sense, I might add, "The good news is that we can help the brain out here. We can give it the message, 'This is a memory. It isn't current.' And often simply knowing that can be very orienting and soothing."

Okay, so once a general description of the science is laid-out, there are two directions you can go. One is from coherence therapy and is called the "**I'm in memory exercise**," and other is from IFS and is a particular type of negotiation with exiles to assist in '**unblending**.' I'll describe both on the next two pages.

Regulating Overwhelmed States (3)

"I'm in Memory Exercise"

The "I'm in Memory Exercise" comes out of coherence therapy (and is outlined in more depth in the book "Unlocking the Emotional Brain"), and is designed for flooded states that relate to a particular trigger.

When doing the "I'm in Memory Exercise," you would first want to explain the science / reasoning behind the exercise, much like I did on the last page (or read Bruce Ecker's way of describing it in the above-mentioned book). Then you might say something like:

"Alright, Kat, if you will, put a hand over your heart. And I'm going to say some statements and I want you to repeat after me. Ready? Okay. 'When my wife is late getting home, and I can't reach her (pause while they repeat), it reminds me of all those times when mom would leave me with my cold dad, and I didn't know when she'd be back, and I felt so alone and forsaken'. Great. Okay, now just pat your heart gently and say: 'it felt so horrible back then, and this situation is reminding me of it'. Great, now let's do it one more time, and I'll lead you again."

When doing the "I'm in Memory Exercise," the client is offered the statement on a card (or email) and given the homework to read it to themselves at any moment of the particular trigger causing intense distress. Although here I'm outlining this exercise for the sake of emotion regulation (which has value itself), in truth this exercise has the potential to also be a moment of memory reconsolidation. Why? Because the network that holds the memory of the pain 'believes' the pain (from the past) is happening now. As mentioned, because traumatic memories are more likely to be held unconsciously or implicitly, they fail to get updated with current reality, and additionally (when triggered) actively predict that the danger or difficultly is current. Therefore, to feel the activation, while witnessing that it is just a memory, has the potential to serve as a mismatch. It might need to be repeated a number of moments, but each time is likely to lessen the activation ongoingly, through actually changing the 'prediction' held by that neural network.

Regulating Overwhelmed States (4)

"Unblending from Exiles"

Now let's look at how overwhelm is handled in IFS work. Their approach is similar to the "I'm in Memory Exercise," (and many trauma therapy techniques, in fact), in that the point is to get some 'observing' distance from the part/memory that is being activated. Trauma therapists call this 'differentiation work.' While there are many ways to do it, it is very naturally accomplished during parts work through the process of 'unblending' (which means to bring an observing awareness toward a part in a mindful way). And while it is possible to have a protector part who has a lot of emotional activation, usually when someone is overwhelmed it is because they are 'blended' with an exile. Really this is the same idea as having an emotional flashback, just described through 'parts language', where the exile has blended with the Self (ie taken over the seat of consciousness), and the goal is to help it to understand that it would be in its best interests to pull back a bit (unblend).

Because IFS is a very relational model (where we relate to our inner processes as if they are people), here's how what they might say to a client: "What I'm thinking is that a very young/hurt part of you has filled up your awareness, and we actually need to ask it to step back a bit. But here's the thing: often these parts flood us because they are so sick of being stuffed in the closet and need us to finally see the pain they carry. So we will need to explain to him/her/them that we want them to give you a bit more breathing room. But NOT so that we can push them away again, but rather so that you have just enough room to actually *be* with them. You see, when this young part floods you, your adult self goes away. And then the young one is simply alone again. Which is not what they want. So if we can gently explain that to this part, it may be willing to step back just a bit, and pull some of its big feelings back into its own body, so that you can stay fully present to listen to and support it. I'd be happy to speak directly to this part too, if that feels better. I believe we can work as a team on this, and help this part get its needs met and be heard--without having to overwhelm you." Of course, if the part is willing to pull back, then you'd have to keep your side of the promise of then fully listening to it.

Regulating Overwhelmed States (5)

Additional Thoughts:

The previous two exercises are a bit more around a particular (old) pain or memory being reactivated (which is probably usually at play). But there is also the possibility of ANY emotion feeling overwhelming due to a schema that emotions are dangerous. So this would be a more general fear of emotion or pain, versus fear of reliving a *particular* painful experience they had historically. I don't think this is a clear distinction (probably both are usually at play to one degree or another), but if you notice that *any* emotional accessing is triggering for the person, you can wonder if there's a general phobia of (usually negative) emotion(s).

Obviously titration and co-regulation (and all the pieces we explored in the 'two channels' discussion) will be very applicable here. It can be helpful to name the fear of emotion (and why it might be coherent given their history), or even do coherence work around this (through crafting a schema statement, as outlined later…in fact, the example schema statement I give on pg. 50 is around fear of emotion). But whether you craft a whole statement, or just briefly explore how they seem to have anxiety/shame around emotions, the eventual place you will want to go is to get their permission to purposefully 'move toward' the emotion "in small enough steps" (as Bruce Ecker would say). You can do this in any way that feels natural, but this can begin to look like AEDP work.

One more offering: systems centered therapy (SCT), has some useful thoughts on helping people stay grounded. One thing they've noticed is that people can feel overwhelmed when there is more than one emotion and they haven't been separated and named. They have a '**facts and feelings**' technique, where they have the person name the facts (note: "He abandoned me," isn't a fact; "He was 30 minutes late" is a fact), and then find the feeling(s) that goes with each fact. Additionally, when people seem to be stuck in a schema that is equating past to present, then it can be helpful to **name 10 differences** between the past / present (or between my father and husband, for instance). I have found this can be incredibly regulating, and a helpful step (again, from SCT).

STEP 3:
DISCOVERING AND WORKING WITH WHAT IS UNDERNEATH

STEP 3:
DISCOVERY WORK

OPTION 1: COHERENCE WORK

OPTIONS 2: COMPLETION WORK

The previous pages explored the pieces of work I call “Contact” and “Clarity,” and while I put them first because they are foundational requirements that make inner exploration possible, they are truly elements that continue through all of the stages of work. In other words, you will always be supporting CONTACT (mindful witnessing / unblending), and CLARITY (focusing on one piece or part at a time). Keeping those in place is what allows for Discovery work to unfold.

As you are doing Discovery work, there are two equally valid pieces worth exploring: either emotions (which then can move into COMPLETION work), or emotional learnings (schemas, which is what we might call COHERENCE work). Likely you will do some of both, and that work can happen in either order, or go back and forth, as the work progresses. I will say, I tend to lean into COHERENCE work first, because if I can get a really clear view of the emotional learning, I will know more exactly what *kind* of COMPLETION (if any) might be needed (in order to serve as a disconfirmation).

AEDP therapists, on the other hand, lean right into COMPLETIONS (discovering emotions and ‘working them through’). These therapists (and others) put emotional processing (completion) at the center, and assume ‘understanding’ (coherence) will emerge as needed. Conversely, Coherence therapists put Coherence work at the center, and assume that emotional processing will emerge as needed. There’s really no right or wrong, and you can decide what approach suites you or the client.

Think of it like this:

When doing Discovery work, there are 2 things worth discovery (so 2 things we listen for). They are:

Which can move into completion work as they process that suffering.

1) What the person suffered.

2) What they learned from that suffering.

Which can move into coherence work as they discover a schema (which will later be held against whatever 'disconfirmation' we create for the purpose of memory reconsolidation.)

STEP 3: COHERENCE WORK

Coherence work is all about discovering what emotional learnings (schemas, imprints, unconscious expectations) make sense of the client's suffering (or 'symptom'). This work looks like crafting questions (or visualizations, etc.) aimed at helping reveal the 'urgent purpose' or schema underneath the symptom.

Every schema has two parts:
1) the **knowledge of a suffering** or problem, and
2) the **knowledge of how to avoid that suffering** or problem.

The aim is ultimately to create a 'juxtaposition' that works to 'disconfirm' either part of the emotional knowing (more on that later).

But before we can move into searching for disconfirmations, we must first discover and map out the schema...both in terms of what problem or suffering it knows about, and ways (if any) it has learned to avoid it. (I say 'if any' because sometimes schemas know that there is some danger, and NO solution or means of avoiding it. Often disconfirmations here relate to realizing they DO have solutions / resources now they didn't have when young).

Any time you are doing Coherence work, you are asking the deeper mind what it *knows* (predicts, expects, anticipates, fears, etc.). In IFS work, this looks like asking a protector part what it fears would happen if it didn't do its job (or even how an exile made sense of things, perhaps assuming it was their fault, for instance). Any time you are asking about what was learned, you are doing coherence work, and have a chance to outline a schema.

For a detailed analysis of how Coherence Therapy approaches this work, I would suggest purchasing the "Coherence Therapy Manual" on Amazon. But you can also use IFS techniques. I'll just try to outline some of the key techniques from both these theories on the next pages.

COHERENCE THERAPY'S DISCOVERY PROCESS

Doing discovery work around coherence does not need to be technique-heavy. Simply slowing down, inviting the client to look inward for what they know about this (with a tone of voice that invites listening for new awareness, rather than saying what they already know). You might say:

"Hmmm. So right here. I wonder if somewhere inside you know something about this..."
Or "Just check inside. See what you know about this..." "Let's slow down here, because I wonder if you know something about being left behind (or whatever the trigger is)."

This simple, conversational approach is called 'empathic eliciting,' where you ask very specifically what the client predicts or what danger or problem they anticipate. Another example of it would be:

"So you find yourself in that moment really staying quiet. Yes, I see. So I guess that leads me to wonder whether some part of your previous experience taught you that it is dangerous in some way, or not a good idea, to voice your concerns. Some experience where it didn't go so well. Does anything come to mind about this?"

If the client names a particular fear (like, "If I'm not perfect, I'll be left behind,"), then you might ask, "What's the worst or strongest you've ever experienced of that...of being left behind?" (Pretty heavy-hitting question, so I would ask it as part of inviting us to slow down, showing non-verbally that I'm right there with them).

This kind of coherence work has a conversational, exploratory tone as we try to figure out how things deeply make sense. But it isn't heady. We want it to be 'bottom-up', so we slow down, encourage answers to come from within, stay curious, give space for new awareness to emerge, etc.
There are some techniques you can use, and those will be outlined next.

OVERT STATEMENTS

One of the backbone 'techniques' of Coherence therapy is to use language to try to capture or represent the emotional truths or expectations held by the schema. While these knowings aren't held verbally, when the subcortical brain hears words that closely match what it knows, it does resonate. And it can supply it's own language as well. This is called 'limbic language,' and it tends to be short, emotionally vivid, personal, and direct. Like "I can't bear to be wrong on this!" "If she leaves, no one will love me again!"

So when doing coherence discovery work, it is important to be writing down what you hear the client say, particularly anything that seems like an emotional learning. That way you can ask for more clarification, or even pull the threads together and reflect them back. You might, for instance, say:

"Would you be willing to try saying something out loud? Just as an experiment? To see if it feels true or not as you say it." (Then offer statement as you understand it, with full permission for them to change any part that doesn't feel true as they say it).

OR,
"Okay. So is it like this?: 'If I get even the slightest hint of bad news, I must run through all the worst case scenarios in my mind. I can't *bare* to be caught off guard and unprepared. I must never let myself be surprised by bad things, so I will imagine them first, so they can't shock me.' Is that getting close to it?" (Of course, if such a statement did resonate, we would then need to explore what they know about 'being shocked' as such a terrible thing that they can't handle. So the work is step by step, like reverse engineering.)

Crafting the statement is a collaborative process, and is not our chance to make an interpretation, even though we may tentatively offer some words (mainly drawing on words they already used).

OVERT STATEMENTS (2)

Often one way to begin to get the relevant material for the overt-statement, is to use a technique called ‘SENTENCE COMPLETION‘. In it, you simply ask the client to ‘allow your mind to fill in the rest of the sentence, without pre-thinking what should come.’ Then you begin with the thing the client is doing that is part of their pattern, and leave the rest of the sentence (around why it is urgent or protective) blank.
You might ask:

“So I’ll start a sentence, and I want you to just let your mind complete the sentence. In fact, just keep repeating it about 10 times, without thinking too much. Okay, here’s the sentence: ‘I must never let anyone see me being weak, because if I do...’”

Another powerful way to use overt statements is to direct the statement toward the person involved with the learning. (“Can you picture your mom before you and just tell her candidly, “Mom, you don‘t want to hear about my sadness.”) Some sensitivity is needed here, because it can be difficult to do, particularly if they are likely to imagine the person coming back with an abusive remark (as they would in real life).

If it seem workable, you can ask the client to speak:
1) in the present-tense (all overt statement should be in the present tense!)
2) to the emotionally relevant person(s) (if applicable)
3) while clearly visualizing them (possibly in an emotionally relevant scene)

A Coherence therapist named Faith Curtin put together a beautiful document outlining in depth how to work with over statements. She agreed to let me (and anyone) share it. I have shared it with you on the resource page, and it‘s a great resource since overt statements are core to coherence work. (If you aren’t in my class, you can email me for it).

SYMPTOM DEPRIVATION

If you want to give extra 'juice' to a sentence completion (or just to the Discovery process in general), it can be helpful to first really bring online the network that 'knows' to do exactly as it is doing (ie to launch the symptom). One way to do this is through what is called a '**symptom deprivation**'. In this technique, you ask the client to imagine being *without* their symptom (or doing something that is *not* in line with their pattern), and allow this to stimulate a sense of discomfort for them.

In other words, you walk them through a very vivid moment where the symptom usually shows up, and imagine it NOT showing up. The following example is inspired by one I once heard Bruce Ecker give:

"Okay, so there you are. You just came home. And you walk to the kitchen and pick up the heavy glass you use for liquor. You put a few pieces of ice in the glass. But then, for whatever reason, you just put the glass down and walk away. You don't take a drink at all (pause). Just take a moment to imagine that. Hmm...so what are you noticing inside?"

The idea is that to imagine being without one's 'symptom' (even ones we say we hate), naturally brings on some anxiety or discomfort. When/if it does, you can then ask the discomfort to finish the sentence... "I must go ahead and have that drink, because if I don't..."

The symptom deprivation technique can be very useful, but it does take some practice to make it effective. You could reference the coherence therapy manual for more info, or even check out a free Youtube by Niall Geoghegan called "Coherence Therapy: How to Create a Symptom Deprivation." While coherence therapy isn't the only therapy that at times explores the coherence of a symptom, it certainly does so with the most precision and depth. If you would like to learn about this wonderful form of therapy, please reference my favorite psychology book of all time: "**Unlocking the Emotional Brain**: Memory Reconsolidation and the Psychotherapy of Transformational Change," by Ecker, Ticic, and Hulley.

PARTS WORK

What I just described are some techniques that come out of coherence therapy. But you could certainly use parts work to do coherence work. In the classic IFS protocol, you might ask a proctor part:

"What are you afraid would happen if you didn't XYZ (criticise Beth)"? (Beth being the client's name)

This is not very different than the idea of sentence completion. It's just that it can be useful to use parts language (either as part of a whole process where you unblend and really try to get in touch with a 'part', or just as a simply reference to parts, like, 'okay, so a part of you seems really driven to do XYZ," or "a part of you is alarmed by that idea.")

There really isn't any rule as to whether to do coherence work through parts or not. But here are some things to consider:

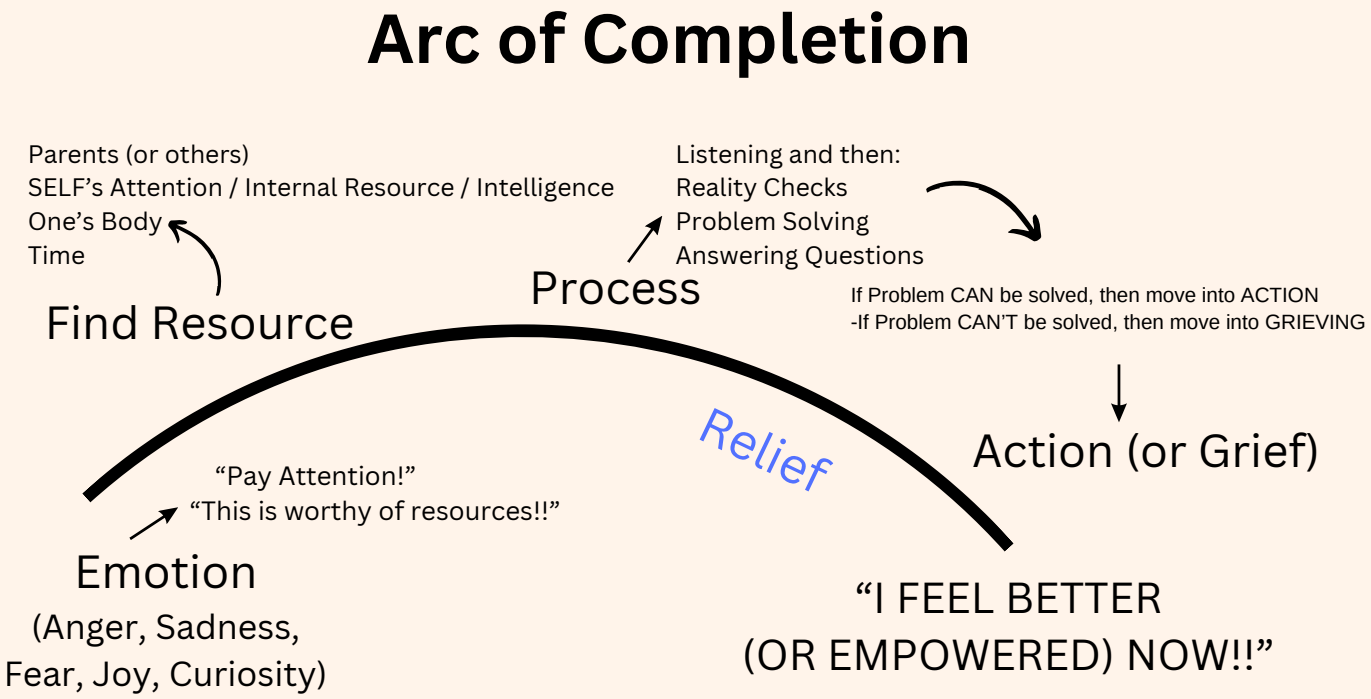
For some people, parts language speeds things up. They get it, and they like it. For others, it actually slows things down. They become preoccupied with the fact that they can't quite picture the part, or aren't sure if it's still 'there,' etc. But while parts tracking can be difficult for some folks (and isn't strictly necessary to the process), it can be particularly effective in these cases:

1) for clients who need help relating to their own inner world with clarity (like seem confused by their conflicted feelings, etc.),
2) for clients who are vulnerable to feeling shame around their issue(s) (although explaining the concept of Coherence can work as well here),
3) for clients who might easily become overwhelmed (and could benefit from unblending).

For people who feel pretty grounded and curious, etc., (perhaps you could say already have enough 'Self energy' online), then I don't always bother with unblending, and might say, "okay, you learned something about this," or, "It feels true that..." instead of 'a *part* of you believes...'

NOW LET'S TALK COMPLETION.

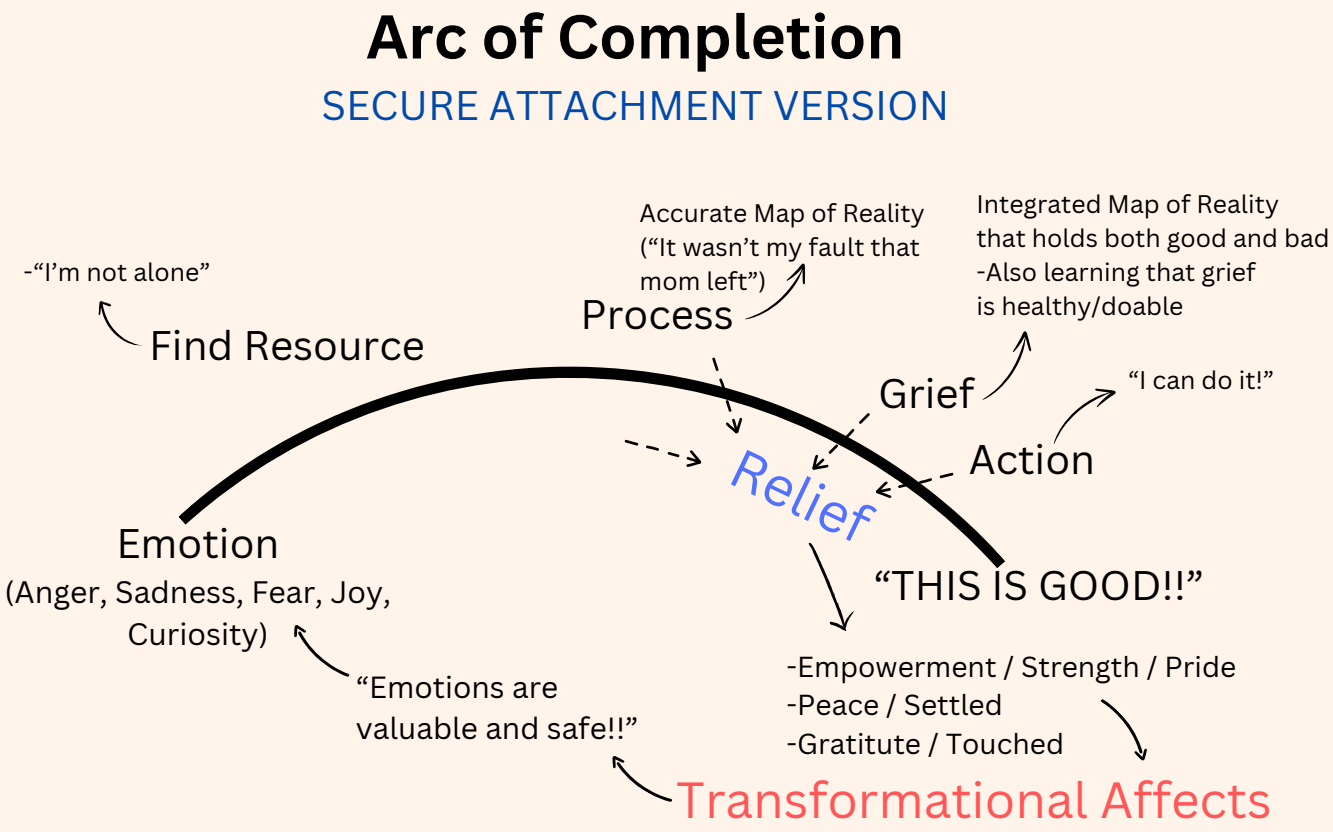
Before we look at what kinds of questions / techniques you might use in completion work, let me share a diagram I made for my students that I call "The Arc of Completion." This arc is meant to capture the natural / healthy flow or progression that is meant to follow emotion (originally where the child runs to the parent for support, and later where the adult turns to their Self (or their 'neocortex') for support). The basic idea is that emotions are there to tell us 'Pay Attention to This! It might be important!' So it cues us to slow down, pay attention (or ask another person to pay attention), so we can look at what information the emotion has for us.



Once the resource is there, the next step is to process it through in terms of understanding or problem-solving. If there is no solution to the problem (that the one emotion is alerting us to), then we use the resource to move into grief. If there *is* an action that can be done, then we move forward, empowered. In short: **emotion is the cue to locate our resources and then get to work**. And if fear, or grief, or anger are blocked, it can lead to problems ('trauma' schemas around emotions being pointless / weak / overwhelming).

On the previous page, there is a diagram that outlines the general requirements for each step in the 'arc of completion.' Below is a diagram that outlines what particular learnings (schemas) are integrated at each step in the case of SECURE ATTACHMENT. I'm sharing this simply so we can reflect on all the various ways that interpersonal support (not just from parents, but later from the therapist, or other important people, or even the SELF) can help one's mind move from a difficult emotion not only toward action, but also toward a wiser, more empowered, more at-ease system. One that has faith that there will be enough resources available (inwardly or outwardly) to make staying with one's true experience not only workable, but desirable.

On the next page we will contrast these learnings with more 'trauma-based' learnings.



On the previous page, the 'secure attachment' version of the Arc of Completion is shown. Below is a diagram that outlines what particular learnings (schemas) are integrated at each step in the case of INSECURE ATTACHMENT. I'm sharing this simply so we can reflect on all the various ways that being neglected, or responded to with shame or cruelty (or even just emotional incompetence), can lead to learnings that diminish our trust not only in others, but in ourselves, our experience, our emotions, our own mind, etc. Thereby leading to emotional suppression (or suppression of particularly painful experiences or themes in the form of exiles). I believe most of us have 'unfinished' completions, whether in the form of unprocessed grief, or anger, or fear (more on fear toward the end of this section).

When we are doing completion work, obviously we are aiming to shift from the 'insecure' set of learnings toward the 'secure' set of learnings, through the experience of finally allowing our full 'arc of completion.'



EMOTIONAL PROCESSING

The first step of emotional processing is to simply ask how someone is feeling. In a strange way, simply being asked about our emotions both orients us to check inside (and therefore makes emotional awareness possible), while ALSO helping it feel safe to see what we find (because it is soothing to think someone cares enough to ask (it 'undoes aloneness')

When there seems to be feelings underneath, you can ask questions like:

"Are there feelings there as you think about this?"

"What are you feeling toward him/her?"

"What's coming up right now?"

"What feelings are there? (Are there some feelings right there?)"

"What are you experiencing right now?"

"What's happening right now? (what's happening inside…?)"

"What are the tears saying?"

"What do you become aware of?"

"Where do you feel that in your body?" (somatic awareness important)

"Can you show me where you feel that inside? Can you put your hand over where you feel that in your body?"

"What sensation is there? Is it cold or hot? Heavy? Buzzy?" (Supply with choices if they are stuck.)

"What are you experiencing viscerally (or physically) right now?"

"What are you tracking?"

"What is it like to hear me say that?"

"What's that like to acknowledge?" (I use this one a lot!)

MOMENT-BY-MOMENT TRACKING

As you move through questions around what the client is feeling, you want to do moment-by-moment tracking. AEDP's 'moment-by-moment tracking,' is similar to my 'two channels,' described previously. In other words, as we are slowly deepening into more awareness of the Needs (Pain, Losses, Feelings, Unprocessed Memories) underneath, we also are deepening into new and deeper levels of resource.

So how does 'moment-by-moment' tracking support this dance (or 'pendulation')? Well, for one, the simple act of noticing what is happening now (being mindful) both supports awareness of the parts inside that *need* awareness (the "Needs"), while at the same time allowing a sense of resource (because the simple act of paying mindful attention is very resourcing). That is why awareness is so powerful. Because it plays 'double duty,' through bringing our full intelligence online, so that we can more deeply see BOTH the pain we hold inside more clearly, while also accessing the resource (ie compassion / mental space / perspective) more clearly.

So you can think of 'moment-by-moment tracking,' as a mindfulness practice...one that's 'moment-by-moment' because the act of being mindful allows a deepening in both channels, which means things are shifting inside! And we want to follow those shifts. Why? Because we will do slightly different things depending on where the client is. If they are hitting up against emotion ("Need"), then we encourage them to stay there (and ask if it is okay to do so). If the material is causing anxiety or shame, then we can help move back toward the Resource Channel. And if the client is noticing their resources / capacity to effectively navigate inwardly (as in: "Oh, that actually feels soothing to say that out loud" or "I feel compassion for myself"), then we can encourage the client to mindfully notice *that* (which is called metaprocessing...more on that later!). Or if they retract from inner awareness (through defenses), that can be addressed. (If you know the 'triangle of conflict,' this will all sound familiar). In short: mindfulness helps the client enter a resourced state AND allows them to accurately report on what is happening, so we know how to help.

Co-Regulation (ala AEDP)

The “moment-by-moment tracking’ (just described) is the cornerstone of a larger frame for using the relationship between client and therapist as a means for deepening into both the resource/needs channel so that emotions can be ‘worked through’ (AEDP term for ‘completion’).

In AEDP, the therapist not only helps the client feel their own internal resources, but also encourages them to notice the resource available through the relational dance itself (so not only *within*, but *between*). This is done through something called ‘co-regulation’. Again, the main key to co-regulation is ‘moment-by-moment tracking’ (where we are following exactly ‘where’ the client is, so we know what kind of help to offer). This is related to the idea of ‘attunement.’

Below are some additional tips from AEDP. These are core elements used when helping people access their emotions and ‘work them through.’

1) Genuine, compassionate contact (between therapist and client, or self-to-part): “I’m right here.” “Can you feel me here with you?”
2) Moment-by-moment tracking “And what’s happening now?”
3) Regulating shame/anxiety, whether interpersonally (ie through therapist’s attunement / compassion), *intra*personally (ie through parts work / self-compassion), through mindful (somatic) awareness (noticing sensation of anxiety w/o judgement), or through tracking coherence (exploring emotional ‘learnings’ under shame/anxiety can be soothing).
4) Continual invitation toward emotion...patient and persistent guidance to notice and *stay with*. “Let’s just linger here.” “Can you make space for the sadness?”
5) Asking permission. Key question: “Is it okay to be with this?” If yes, then, “Great, then just let it move through. This is really important...”. Asking for permission is very regulating.

INNER CHILD WORK (ala IFS)

While pure emotional processing is a common completion that people need, there are other (more imaginal) ways of facilitating completions that never got to happen (from the past). One, of course, is through parts work!! There are many systems that use parts in different ways, but we will stick with good old IFS :)

In IFS, once you have done the (Coherence) work around exploring what protector parts learned to fear, you can simply ask the 'protector': "who inside are you protecting?" Then you can ask them if they are willing to soften back and allow contact with that (usually young) part. There is a lot of guidance IFS gives around this process (beyond what I will outline--and I encourage you to learn more about the official IFS steps if you like parts work), but one key they often use (when parts are scared to soften back), is to ask if they'd be willing to soften back as long as the young part first agrees to not flood "Theo." This negotiation is pretty beautiful, where there is a conversation with the 'exile' ahead of time, explaining that, while you understand why they would flood (because they need to be heard!), it unfortunately simply leaves them once again alone because the adult self is swept offline. You can talk to young parts and very lovingly explain that you need them to hold their emotion a bit separate, so that "Theo" can stay present and finally be fully available to hear them.

Obviously it can be very useful to learn the official IFS steps. But the bottom line is that once you have contact with an exile, it is time to build a relationship. And what is the master key to building a strong relationship, built on trust? **Listening**. Listening is everything. This is not about 'cheering up' the part, or rushing to make them feel better. Yes, one of the first questions to ask is whether the part can feel the adult Self present. But if they do, and just don't want to connect...that's okay! And even just giving permission for the young/hurt part to show up exactly as it wants to can be powerful. This is a version of 'undoing aloneness,' where the goal is to be curious about the hurt part's experience (or even mistrust), rather than immediately change it.

INNER CHILD WORK (2)

Inner child work (ie parts work) is an alternate way to move through the 'arc of completion.' Below I will review how the steps of the arc are accomplished through parts work:

Step 1: Contacting Resource.
When the adult Self is finally available (through unblending with protector parts), the system now has the resource of an adult intelligence (compassion/wisdom, etc.). This allows the system to open to new work and processing. Again, think of this as 'undoing aloneness.'

Step 2: Processing
Processing is all about the child (or exile) informing an adult about what is happening. That way they can work together to find new meaning around it. This is accomplished through the exile saying everything they experienced (again, with the Self at first simply listening). That might range from what happened ('mom left!'), to how painful it was ('I felt so scared!'), to what sense they made of it ('It was my fault!'). While the first step is for the Self to listen, after listening there will likely be truths they can share with the child ("It *wasn't* your fault!" "I am grown and can protect you!" "You are valuable and innocent.") (Disonfirmations).

Step 3: Grief
Grief is about having the resources to begin bearing to metabolize and integrate the hard experience or realities. We can't grieve without a sense of resource / connection / comfort. So once the adult self is there and has begun listening, the whole system can finally begin to grieve. This might look like the child crying on the Self's (client's) lap, etc.

Step 4: Action
Sometimes there are actions that seem clear once processing has happened. So moving into action is often the final step of completion. In IFS, they often ask the client to ask the part whether there is anything they want to do, or have the Self ("Karen") do. Often this is around fighting back, setting a boundary, protecting the child, and finally...taking child to safe place (a tree house, the client's heart, the present moment, etc), where they can live forever after. (In IFS there is also an 'unburdening process,' which I won't review here).

EMPOWERED REENACTMENT

So far we have discussed 'completions' in relation to emotions that lean a bit more 'interpersonal' (where the resource is likely to be relational, and lead into discussions / exploration of needs and problem solving, etc.). The 'completion arc' looks a bit different around fear (at least when triggered by immediate physical danger). Then the 'resource' becomes the body. And the 'processing' phase is truncated down to a only a few seconds of orienting (checking out the danger, looking for an exit, all while staying physically very still). Then right into action (think 'fight or flight').

I think there are interesting parallels between attachment trauma (which is more around interpersonal resource not be available) and physical traumas (which is often about the body not being available--perhaps do to a stuck freeze response--or simply feeling insufficient to protect one's self). Whereas the former leads to schemas like "No one is there for me," or "Sadness is a lonely and overwhelming feeling, without resolution!" the latter leads to schemas around "I can't protect myself! So I'm in danger!" or "*Fear* is a stuck and overwhelming feeling, without resolution!"

In both cases, the disconfirmation becomes a new experience of noticing and allowing inner feeling/activation, and then supporting the process of resource coming online, which allows for completion. If this sounds interesting (or you enjoy somatic approaches), I would recommend training in either Somatic Experiencing, or Sensorimotor Psychotherapy. They both specialize the helping people notice their fear 'activations,' while going slowly enough to stay resourced. This allows freeze to move into completion of 'self-protective responses.' This provides a huge disconfirmations for the schemas that are driving the trauma symptoms.

If you don't want full training in somatic work, but still want to address schemas picked up by physical traumas, I would suggest reading the section in "Unlocking the Emotional Brain," that outlines a version of this called 'empowered reenactment.' The basis of this technique is to simply have the person imagine the scene again, while then imagining themselves doing whatever is necessary to protect themselves / fight back / run away, etc. This is an imaginal way of creating the same kind of disconfirmation (of "I'm powerless") through creating a new experience (in this case through imagery) of effective self-protection.

WORKING WITH ANGER

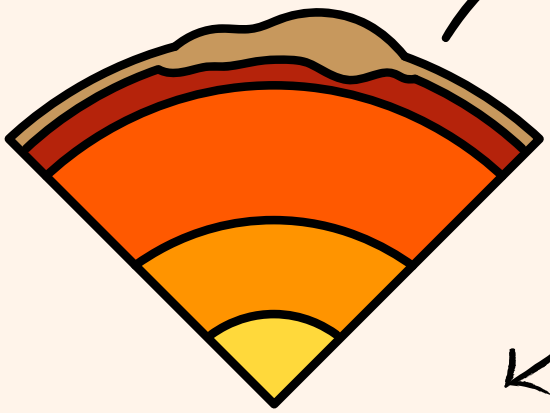
So how does the previous page relate to working with anger, given that anger can be about self-protection? While my sense is that anger is somewhere in between the two 'versions' mentioned previously, I believe anger is ultimately an interpersonal emotion (ie focused on solving interpersonal problems through interpersonal conversations, boundaries, etc.). So whereas fear is about fight/flight for physical safety, anger is more about getting another person's attention with the main aim of **being heard**. Why do we need to be heard? Because we deeply want to influence another person's actions--whether through talking to them, or (if they won't listen), yelling, pushing, physical controlling /punishing. The goal is to make them stop! (or start).

While it usually isn't productive to 'act on' unprocessed anger, it is a very healthy emotion. Like all emotions, it gives information ('pay attention to this!') as well as motivation and energy to act. The problem is, most people have a phobia of anger. Either they saw a parent mishandle their own anger (like in the case of a parent who rages) or repress their own anger (if parents *never* showed anger, that also teaches something). Or the client was shamed / punished for *their* anger. So that is why we need to actively make space for completions around anger in session. This can start off with coherence work if you'd like (exploring messages they picked up from family or culture about anger), or could move straight into moment-by-moment tracking aimed at processing anger through to 'completion'.

When processing anger, you ask all the 'experiential questions,' ("what were you feeling toward her in that moment?," "Where does that anger live in your body?" "Is it okay to be with this and give some space for the anger to be felt?" Additional questions might be: "What does the anger want to say to them?" or even "What does the anger want to do? Right there, in your body. What would you do if you didn't have to hold back at all? I don't mean what you should *actually* do in real life, but just in imagination, what would you want to do to make them stop?" Then you can support the client in imagining a physical response. **Yes, these impulses can be violent**. Often we have deep rage about ways we were abused and couldn't fight back. So it can be incredibly relieving / empowering to let that finally move through in a safe, grounded way. Central to most 'anger processing' is imagining aggressive physical actions the anger 'wants' to do. If that sounds too much, imagining speaking words ("Back the *fuck* off!") can be powerful too.

Let's add another layer, based on what we've covered so far:

Presenting Problem



Clarification

What do you mean exactly?
What do you mean by depression?
What does it look and feel like?

Where/When/With Whom
Context!

Example!!!

SLOW DOWN /
"REVIVIFY" THE SCENE

CONTACT AND INNER EXPLORATION

EXPERIENTIAL QUESTIONS

COHERENCE COMPLETION

STEP 4: INTEGRATING new EXPERIENCE OR KNOWING

ie. “Integration Work“

From coherence therapy

COHERENCE VERSION: “INTEGRATION PHASE”

COMPLETION VERSION: “METAPROCESSING”

From AEDP

STEP 4: INTEGRATING new EXPERIENCE OR KNOWING

ie. "Integration Work"

COHERENCE VERSION (CT): After completing a piece of coherence work, it is important to 'integrate' the new knowing or schema into conscious awareness. This is done in the 'integration' phase during coherence therapy.

COMPLETION VERSION (AEDP): After completing a piece of completion work, it is important to 'integrate' the new experience, (and any new knowings it might spark). This is done during metaprocessing in AEDP.

COHERENCE THERAPY'S INTEGRATION PHASE

People can have powerful experiences, or new 'aha's', that then fall back into the unconscious between sessions. Hence integration work. In Coherence, this typically looks like simply writing on a card (or email) whatever was discovered in session. Of course the goal is to discover the knowing held within a schema, which you work to craft language around during session, but the card holds whatever was learned (not always a whole schema). Then you (together, if you have time), write out the clearest version of this statement, with the homework being to review it every other day for the next week (without trying to argue with it).

Sometimes simply sitting with their 'card' creates spontaneous juxtapositions for folks. But the main purpose is to facilitate integration, so that what was wired unconsciously is now held consciously. This helps with therapeutic focus, so that the next session can start with a check-in: 'What was it like to stay in contact with the contents of the card?'

I got permission (from client) to offer his schema as an example, developed during 2nd session:

"Dad, I learned from you that for a boy to be sad and cry is weak and pathetic. I believed you because to not believe you would put me at risk of behaving in ways that you couldn't stand and wouldn't love. So I had to toughen up! Not only to make you love me, but to avoid that horrible moment of punishment where you made me feel so pathetic and weak for crying.

And it isn't just you, dad. Everyone secretly believes that it is pathetic for a man to cry. So I must, at all costs, not let myself even go near those tears. I must not even feel sad, even if that means I'm less connected to my joy. While I hate feeling disconnected from my full, true self, it is better than being weak, and everyone knowing that I'm weak."

IFS has their own version of integration work, equally simple. The homework in IFS is to simply ask the person to promise their part (if they feel they will follow through) to check-in with them (particularly if it's an exile) every day to renew the connection, and see how they are feeling.

AEDP'S METAPROCESSING

Whereas the above 'integration phase' is used upon completion of a piece of coherence work, if you have finished a piece of completion work, then you would next want to 'metaprocess.'

Metatherapeutic processing, or 'metaprocessing' for short, comes out of AEDP. Metaprocessing is an opportunity to slow down after an important piece of work and process it (hens the word 'meta' because you are 'processing the process'). When people finally move through a whole successful completion (particularly around core wounds, but even just around feelings about current life), it is a powerful experience. After core emotions are processed, people almost invariable experience what are called 'transformational affects,' such as relief, joy, peace, gratitude, strength, clarity, etc. Sometimes they feel another round of grief for only now having this experience. In Fosha's mind, these emotions are important to explore as well.

To use our language, transformational affects should have their own 'completion'. After all, emotions are all around 'hey, process this! It is important and deserves attention!' and even these positive emotions have something they need to process, which is, "Wow, what just happened? Why was that so great? How did we get here? My goodness...I think I see something new about what we just explored...I really see how my parents were trying their best...etc, etc." Why the last insight? Well, once we are freed up from the grip of the negative emotion, and are finally bringing our adult insight into the whole thing, we are likely to see new things that we never saw before, or have a new perspective that we couldn't find when we were either fully immersed in the distress (or actively avoiding it).

In AEDP, they call this 'autobiographical reconstruction,' but it basically just means that if you take the chance (after a piece of work) to linger, explore how good it feels, and look again at what was being discussed, it is likely you will see something new. Not only about your story, but, very centrally, about whether it is safe to feel, and be seen by another.

METAPROCESSING QUESTIONS

"What are you experiencing now?"

"Oh, some calm? Yeah...just let yourself really be with that calm."

"Where are experiencing that in your body?"

"Oh, throughout your chest? Yeah. Just let that live there. Hmm...What is it like to be with this new state?"

"You feel some pride? Oh wow. Yeah, where do you feel that pride....yeah, just let it move up your spine like that. Wow, I can see how it really supports you to sit taller. Huh."

"Yeah, if you can just let that happen, and just really notice what it is like to sit taller...is it okay to feel this pride?"

"I wonder...what does this pride know? Just feel inside and see what the Pride knows that didn't feel clear before."

"Just notice anything else you become aware of, as we linger here with this new calm (or joy)..."

"Oh, you're feeling gratitude toward me? Yeah, thank you for sharing that. I'm feeling a lot of gratitude toward you as well. And so touched by the work we did together. So delighted to be a part of it. What is it like to hear me say that?"

So, how long to continue metaprocessing? Really we can stay with it until the client has no more to add. This might just be five minutes, but often is fifteen or more (I've spent whole sessions metaprocessing!). So don't worry if it is feeling long ("Um, I think I'm supposed to be helping them with their *problems*?"), because this is powerful (and rich with new information that can serve as disconfirmations). My friend Juliane Taylor Shore love reciting poetry to help the new experience land. Pretty cool.

STEP 5: TRANSFORMATION THROUGH JUXTAPOSITION

STEP 5: TRANSFORMATION THROUGH JUXTAPOSITION

Once you have done either a successful piece of completion or coherence work, the next step is to aim toward the creation of what (in CT) is called a 'juxtaposition experience.' There are two things needed for this experience: 1) activation of the original prediction / knowing / schema and 2) awareness of information that subjectively, but decisively, contradicts it.

Now, much of the time this 'disconfirmation' will naturally have emerged during STEP 4. Why? Well, in coherence work, as soon as the schema is clearly stated, if the person already has access to disconfirming knowledge, it will likely pop up. What about during metaprocessing? There too, just in reverse!

In other words, metaprocessing is all about sitting and witnessing the disconfirming evidence first, but doing so will likely bring the original schema into awareness. Although AEDP therapists don't map out this schema ahead, often when in metaprocessing, people will naturally say, "Hey, this is not what I thought would happen if I allowed myself to feel my sadness (or anger)!" They may have other spontaneous juxtapositions as well (like I mentioned can happen when they look back at whatever painful life experience they just processed from a newly centered, empowered position). Of course, if you are doing emotional processing, and the person lands in a more expansive or at-ease place, you can contribute to the juxtaposition by asking, "Is this what you expected it would be like to move through some grief today?"

Okay, while juxtapositions often can naturally emerge after STEP 4 (probably do so about half the time), they don't always do so. So we will discuss how to actively search for juxtapositions next!

IDEAS FOR DISCONFIRMATIONS

As mentioned, about half the time, when the client simply states the contents of their schema with full awareness and consciousness in session--doing so immediately triggers a 'wait a minute! I know that isn't true!'. Not of the cognitive kind, but of actual deeply held knowing that feels true enough to serve as a disconfirmation. In that case, the therapist would immediately want to ask the client to expand upon this 'other' knowing, and then serve both the old and the new 'aha' together at the same time (thereby creating a juxtaposition).

However, if this doesn't happen, then the therapist needs to consider what kind of experience, or imagery, or line of questioning, might help a disconfirmation come into awareness.

All sorts of options for creating disconfirmations are outlined in the Coherence Therapy manual. They can be as simple as asking if the client has ever had an experience where things *didn't* go as expected by the schema.

"Have you ever had an experience when XYZ didn't happen? (...you honestly expressed a need to someone and they didn't shame you for it?)"

I created a document that list out some possible avenues for disconfirmations, all linked to the 'arc of completion' (because we had discussed the various types of learnings that can happen when different parts of the arc are disrupted). That document offers ideas around disconfirmation for learning across the arc, and is called "Ideas for Disconfirmation." My higher-tier Patreon folks have access to this, as well as any of my training group students.

For now, what I will do (in the next page) it simply list out the options outlined in the CT manual (and you can refer to the manual for the full description on how to use them).

IDEAS FOR DISCONFIRMATIONS (FROM CT MANUAL)

Already Existing Knowledge

As simple as asking if they ever had an experience that didn't go along with the schema's expectation.

Imagery / "Structured Revisiting"

-Inner Child Work. For instance, IFS work with exiles can disconfirm schemas re: aloneness / shame, or powerlessness (redos). Or hope in change (unburdening exile). Or need for self-protection (unburdening protector part, after witnessing exile is now okay). If you already outlined schema, you can craft revisiting more carefully with schema in mind.

-Empowered Reenactment (as described earlier)

-De-suppression of suppressed traumatic memory to prove they can handle it (using "small enough steps", or 'pendulation')

Client-therapist Relationship

Self-Revelation by Others

This kind of disconfirmation is more likely to happen in the context of couples or group therapy, but might happen in their daily life as well.

Experiential Psychoeducation

While psychoeducation is usually not 'experiential', it occasionally can be provided in a way that truly lights up a new knowing. As an example, if the emotional learning is that not fighting off a sexual assault means we are weak, learning about the 'freeze' response might be very impactful.

(Completion)

I would add to this list 'completion' work, particularly for schemas around fear of emotional processing/grief/anger/fear. Working emotions through to completion can powerfully disconfirm fear of emotional experience and emotional expression / closeness. Of course 'inner child work' and 'empowered reenactement' (above) are also versions of completion work.

JUXTAPOSITION EXPERIENCE

Creating a juxtaposition is quite simple. In fact, all the hard work is simply in getting to the point where a true juxtaposition can be made...with the two core ingredients being two, subjectively real-feeling truths (the schema, and the disconfirmation), that both cannot be true at the same time.

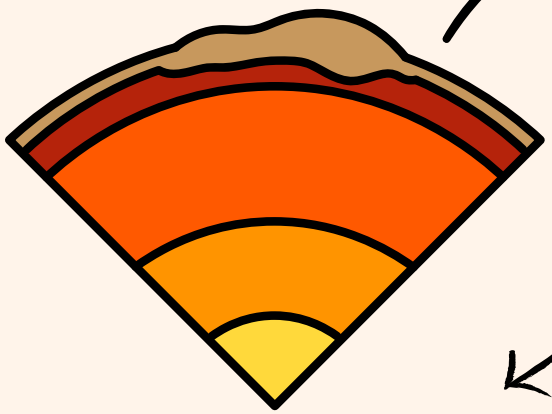
This template is often useful:
"Let's go over two things that seem to feel true to you. If you will, allow yourself to actually feel these things as we review them. First, what you learned in life very deeply is that (review the contents of the schema as captured by the overt statement), and second, that you've had experiences that clearly show you XYZ" (ie, "and second, that you just now are seeing that you can fully touch into the anger, and actually stay grounded at the same time)."

As you set up this experience, you aren't favoring one over the other ("you used to think this false thing, but now you see the truth..."). No, you want to leave judgement out of it, and simply hold both knowings side by side, trusting their brain to register the mismatch.
Then you might simply ask, "How is it to be in touch with both?" It is important to review the juxtaposition, in its specificity, at least twice more during the next minutes, which is usually easy to do quite naturally.

If you are doing IFS work, you could easily do this using parts language. "So some part of you has always believed XYZ, but now you can clearly see ABC." For instance: "Wow. So this sweet boy is really showing you how it was his fault that he got teased. But from your perspective, you can really now see how it wasn't his fault at all." Or "Yes, let's bring back that protector part we started with. The one who always knew it was absolutely urgent to make sure you were never made to feel small again. Let's let that part witness that young part now, and how he knows he's good and enough. Can the part see that?"

THAT'S IT!
THE NEXT (AND LAST) PAGE WILL SIMPLY GIVE THE FINAL VISUAL WITH ALL OF THE LAYERS OF THE WORK INCLUDED.

LAYERS OF THE WORK



Presenting Problem

Clarification

What do you mean exactly?
What do you mean by depression?
What does it look and feel like?

Where/When/With Whom
Context!

Example!!!

SLOW DOWN /
“REVIVIFY” THE SCENE

CONTACT AND INNER EXPLORATION

EXPERIENTIAL QUESTIONS

COHERENCE COMPLETION

Integration

JUXTAPOSITION

THOUGHTS ON INTEGRATING BETWEEN MODELS

Before we end, I would like to offer some reflections on the strategy of integrating between models, versus fully mastering one model. I personally so deeply enjoy learning that I can't hold myself back from learning many approaches. And then consequently my teaching becomes integrative, because I teach what know. I also lean toward integration because when the goal is memory reconsolidation, it can certainly be useful to have a wide variety of tools (or even frameworks) from which you can pull from and integrate as needed. In other words, there is potentially something quite wonderful about the idea of using the brain's requirement for memory reconsolidation as the overarching frame, and then drawing on techniques to support those requirements.

That being said, one could make a strong case for specializing in one (or maybe two) theoretical approaches. In fact, after my students complete my core training (which hopefully introduces them to the unique strengths of some major types of experiential therapy), my advice to my students is to pick a 'theoretical home,' i.e. a model that can serve as their home-base. And this is the advice I would like to give to you. While I would love you to feel free to use this manual as a crash-course in some of the experiential basics, and as a frame for integrating between various approaches you have already learned aspects of, at the same time I think it can be incredibly helpful to learn at least one theory fully--from top to bottom. If you haven't yet done so then perhaps reading this manual will have helped you identify which way of working most speaks to your soul and aligns with your values or strengths.

When discussing this with my students, I like to point out that there are two main archetypes we therapists can fit into. One is that of a midwife, and one is that of a detective (or scientist). I encourage my students to think about which more fits their personality / passion. Some have expressed really loving showing up like a midwife, where their presence and attunement allows a natural movement inside the client's system (i.e. the movement toward completion or emotional processing). And others have been more drawn to the idea of being a detective, where they are bringing their curiosity and 'Socratic Questions' to the mission of outlining schemas (getting to the 'why' the client is stuck in the

THOUGHTS ON INTEGRATING BETWEEN MODELS (2)

pattern they seem to be stuck in), and then figuring out the exact kind of experience needed to disconfirm the need for that pattern (i.e. the schema). I would encourage you to reflect on which archetype feels most exciting and comfortable to you, and start there. If you like the idea of showing up as a midwife who leads with compassion in order to support an organic, natural process of inner healing and emotional awakening, then you might want to delve into more AEDP training (or other emotion-focused or even somatic approaches, like Hakomi). If you like the idea of being a detective who leads with their curiosity to discover what is underneath the issue at hand, all while showing the client that their inner world makes sense and there are 'no bad parts,' then you might want to delve into training in coherence therapy (which of course is additionally the therapy that is most clearly aimed at memory reconsolidation), though IFS would also fit this description. If you are somewhere in between, you might enjoy training in IFS, which toggles between more coherence and completion work, and has the added benefit (or drawback, depending on your system), of not requiring the therapist to serve as the stand-in attachment figure because the focus is on teaching the client how to be their own source of support and security.

That being said, of course there are some people, like me, who simply want to be integrative, and those students of mine tend to just stick with me, moving from the Minding the Heart training into video-based consultation groups, or other spaces where we can discuss integration. So the most important thing is finding the path that will work for you! But I just wanted to add some thoughts here on the importance of being intentional about your direction, where you fully consider whether to go through the 'core trainings' offered by whatever approach is more attractive to you. Of course, it wouldn't hurt to go through my core training (Minding the Heart) either before or after, to help deepen your understanding of WHY these models do what they do.

I won't list out the resources for the AEDP, IFS, and coherence therapy trainings, because you can easily find their core training programs, as well as books and other resources, on their website. And of course I have a series on each of these models on my youtube channel.

CONGRATS! You've finished this insane document! I hope this manual was helpful, though of course it is meant to go alongside my core 6-month training called, "Minding the Heart." If you'd like to learn from me 'live,' feel free to check out the trainings I offer on my website.

BEST OF LUCK IN YOUR WORK!! ;)

Warmly, *Tori*

